



Less adverts = more power

Android apps without ads could be twice as power efficient, say Purdue University/Microsoft researchers

Drunk on money

NYT has cut the number of articles per month to 10 for free users. It claims to have 4,54,000 paid users



No home theatre setup is complete without a Blu-ray player. Despite being limited in number, deciding on one is tough

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The last few months have been critical for Blu-ray players. After the much needed price reduction bringing some versions below the ₹10,000 price bracket, this device found its way into many home theatre setups. Consumers are using it to play DVDs, Blu-rays and even media from an external USB drive.

But, it hasn't been smooth sailing for them all through. The price of Blu-ray discs is still on the higher side and the limited availability, both in terms of titles and store stocks doesn't help either. The root cause of piracy and the rise of online downloads is pretty much obvious. And while

we don't condone it, piracy ensures that most users get these otherwise exorbitantly priced movies for free – either in SD or HD versions. This is where the USB and backwards compatibility with DVDs come into play, helping Blu-ray players compete head on with HD media players.

Even though there aren't too many Blu-ray players in the market, buying one is still a tough decision. More so because of the feature set. Within this test, we have distinct varieties of players – plain vanilla Blu-ray players, 3D playback compatible players and 2D to 3D upscalable players. We hope that this test will provide clarity on the smartest choice when it comes to buying a Blu-ray player in the near future.

The participants

For this edition of the Blu-ray player test, we received two devices from Philips, two from Panasonic and one each from Sony and LG. On contacting Samsung, they informed us that a new Blu-ray player range would be launched in India sometime this summer, and wouldn't be participating at the moment. Look out for individual reviews in Bazaar once we have the units for review. You may be surprised to also see the Sony PlayStation 3 Slim in this comparison test, since it also has full-fledged Blu-ray playback capabilities.

Look and feel

If you took a quick look at all the players, you'd probably think "Ha! They look just the same", but on further inspection,

you'll see the subtle and not-so-subtle differences.

Let's kick off with the Philips BDP3200. The fascia is divided into two parts – the glossy top portion and the slightly angled bottom portion with a fake brushed metal finish. The glossy portion is where the Blu-ray drive sits towards the left and you find a USB port towards the right.

While it isn't visible when the BDP3200 is turned off, there's a display right next to the USB. All four hardware keys sit on the angled portion below the drive and the USB port. Circular buttons are well marked, and the power key lights up in red in stand-by mode. The top portion is completely metal with a classy light black finish. On the back you'll find all majority of the connectivity options. Since this player doesn't come with inte-